◇ // VISUAL DIRECTION SPEC — V1.0 — HYBRID

Soft *Signal*

gxsc foundation · metalheart geometry · late 1980s–early 2000s synthesis

◇ AESTHETIC DNA

URBAN NATURALISM · BOTANICAL MOTIFS · METRO & TRANSIT · GEOMETRIC UNDERLAYER · MECH SURFACE TEXTURE · CORNER BRACKETS · SIGNAL THROUGH FOG · WARM + COLD TENSION · POST-BRITPOP · ELECTRONICA · Y2K SYNTHESIS

> *GXSC's quiet warmth and observational calm is the ground. Metalheart's geometry and texture are the signal beneath it — visible only when you look for it. Corner brackets at panel edges. A grid barely perceptible through linen. A rhombus where a bullet point might have been. The machine is there, but it doesn't shout.*

◇ COLOUR PALETTE

Fog	Mist	Linen	Stone	Midnight
#EDEAE4	#E2DFD8	#B8B4AC	#8F8B83	#1C1B1B
Page bg	Surface bg	Raised panel	Borders	Headings

Sage	Steel	Signal	Warm clay	Amber dim
#9E7F72	#5869F7A	#5ABFAR	#8C7B6A	#A8BC5A-80%
Nature accent	Urban accent	Geo / HUD accent	Organic accent	Geo / warm geo

KEY HYBRID RULE

The Signal colour (#5ABFAR) is the Metalheart inheritance — it's the muted, fog-filtered version of Metalheart's cyan. It appears only in geometric elements: brackets, grid underlays, rhombuses, scan lines, and HUD bars. It never colours text or fills large surfaces. The overall palette remains GXSC warm and muted; Signal is only the machine visible through the mist.

◇ TYPOGRAPHY

Signal through *the fog*

DISPLAY HEADING — DM Sans · 300 · -0.5px · italic for atmosphere

The grid is there, beneath the linen. You see it only at certain angles — the way you see the steel structure of a Victorian railway terminus through its ornate facade.

BODY COPY — DM Sans · 300 · 14px · 1.75 leading

▸ PLATFORM 4 · SIGNAL NOMINAL · 23:14
0x4A · subsystem: transit · bearing: north

HYBRID LABEL — DM Mono · 300 · GXSC wayfinding + Metalheart data cadence

◇ GEOMETRIC DECORATIVE LANGUAGE

SHAPES — METALHEART FORMS, SIGNAL PALETTE, FOG-OPACITY

SURFACE EFFECTS — SCAN LINES, GRIDS, CHROME GRADIENTS

USAGE RULE

Geometric elements are always at low opacity (6–22% fill, 20–35% stroke) and in Signal colour only — except amber-warm rhombuses used as decorative counterpoints. Shapes appear as: section label prefixes (▸), corner brackets on panels, background grid underlays, decorative dividers, and HUD-style data bars. They are never foreground elements, never interactive, and never crowd the layout.

◇ SURFACE TREATMENTS

FOG · BASE	MIST · SURFACE	LINEN · RAISED
Pure GXSC	Pure GXSC	Bead-blast tonal

GRID UNDERLAY	SCAN TEXTURE	CHROME GRADIENT
Hybrid · Metalheart	Hybrid · Metalheart	Hybrid · Metalheart

Fog, mist, and linen are the primary surfaces — pure GXSC. Grid, scan, and chrome surfaces are used sparingly for structural or feature panels where a Metalheart texture is appropriate (e.g. data dashboard section, a technology feature panel). Never use textured surfaces for body content or reading areas.

◇ UI PATTERNS

Overview · Collection · Signal · Archive

FIELD TRANSMISSION · SPRING

Platform 4 · 23:14 northbound

The kind of quiet that only exists between the last train and the first. The grid of the city visible in the windows, the geometry of departure boards, the fog on everything.

MARCH 2001 — READ →

ALTITUDE	TEMP	OVERCAST
76 m	8°c	92%

◇ BORDER & CONTAINER LANGUAGE

Stone border — standard GXSC card or panel

Signal border — HUD panels, data zones, tech features

Sage border — botanical, nature, or urban green zones

Amber-warm border — accent / counterpoint, used rarely

GXSC left rule — pull quotes, asides, atmospheric notes

Signal left rule — technical callouts, data annotations

Border radius: 0px throughout. Corner brackets (pseudo-elements, 10–14px) replace rounded corners as the primary panel decoration — this is the core Metalheart contribution to the hybrid. All borders are 1px only.

◇ DESIGN TOKENS

TOKEN	VALUE	USAGE
Border radius	`0px`	All elements — no rounding. Corner brackets instead.
Corner bracket size	`10–14px`	Panel corners — primary container decoration
Grid opacity	`0.04–0.08`	Background grid underlay (RGBA signal colour)
Geo shape fill	`0.06 opacity`	Rhombuses, hexagons, etc. (signal colour)
Geo shape stroke	`0.22–0.35 opacity`	Outline of decorative shapes
Heading weight	`300`	Always thin — GXSC rule, no exceptions
HUD bar height	`1px`	Thinner than Metalheart — GXSC restraint
Scan line opacity	`0.04`	Much quieter than Metalheart's 0.025+
Signal colour	`#5ABFAR`	Geometric elements only — never body text
Transition	`0.2s ease`	Slow and calm — GXSC pacing
Shadow	`none`	Never — GXSC absolute rule
Panel padding	`18–28px`	Generous — GXSC breathing room

◇ HARD RULES

GXSC is the ground. All decisions default to GXSC restraint unless Metalheart geometry is specifically warranted.

Geometric elements are always background, structural, or decorative — never foreground, never interactive.

Signal colour (#5ABFAR) exists only for geometric elements: grids, brackets, shape outlines, HUD bars. Never for text.

Never use pure white or pure black — fog and midnight only.

Never use border-radius — corner brackets are the rounding substitute.

Never use drop shadows — surface layering creates depth.

Never use headings heavier than 300 weight — even with Metalheart geometry present.

Grid and scan textures are reserved for data/tech feature panels — never on reading or editorial surfaces.

Amber-warm geometry is the rarest note — use at most once per screen as a single counterpoint shape.

The machine is always felt, never seen. If the geometry is noticeable, it is too strong.